WEEK 12: ACCEPTANCE & MINDFULNESS

Clean Pain vs. Dirty Pain

One of the most powerful concepts in ACT is the distinction between clean pain and dirty pain.

CLEAN PAIN is the unavoidable discomfort that comes with being human.

- Anxiety about important things
- Sadness when you lose something
- Loneliness when disconnected
- The urge itself
- Disappointment when things don't work out

Clean pain is part of life. You can't avoid it.

DIRTY PAIN is the suffering we create by fighting clean pain.

- Anxiety about having anxiety ("I shouldn't feel this way")
- Shame about sadness ("Real men don't cry")
- Isolation because of loneliness ("I have to hide this")
- Panic about urges ("This urge means I'm broken")
- Despair about disappointment ("I'll never succeed")

Dirty pain is optional. It comes from struggling against reality.

THE FORMULA:

Clean Pain + Struggle = Dirty Pain

Example:

Clean pain: You feel anxious about a work presentation.

Struggle: "I shouldn't feel anxious. This means I'm weak. I can't handle this. I need to make it go away."

Dirty pain: Now you're anxious about being anxious. You feel shame. You act out to escape. You create more problems.

Alternative (Acceptance): "I'm anxious about this presentation. That makes sense—it matters to me. I can feel anxious AND still do what I need to do."

The Problem with Avoidance

You've spent years trying to avoid uncomfortable feelings. How has that worked?

What avoidance looks like:

- Using sexual behavior to escape anxiety
- Isolating to avoid vulnerability
- Staying busy to avoid boredom
- Numbing out to avoid pain

What avoidance costs:

- Your life gets smaller
- The feelings get bigger
- You never learn you can handle discomfort
- You lose connection to what matters

The polygraph metaphor:

Imagine being hooked up to a polygraph machine. You're told: "Don't get anxious, or you'll get shocked."

What happens? You get MORE anxious. Because trying NOT to feel something makes you focus on it more.

The harder you fight against feelings, the more powerful they become.

Acceptance ≠ Resignation

Let's be clear about what acceptance is and isn't.

ACCEPTANCE IS NOT:

- Liking what's happening
- Wanting things to stay the same
- Giving up on change
- Tolerating harmful behavior

- Being passive or weak

ACCEPTANCE IS:

- Acknowledging reality as it is
- Making room for uncomfortable experiences
- Allowing feelings without acting on them
- Choosing your response instead of reacting automatically
- Being willing to experience discomfort in the service of what you value

---

THE DIFFERENCE:

Resignation: "I'm going to have urges forever, so what's the point? I might as well give in."

Acceptance: "I'm going to have urges. That's part of being human and part of recovery. I can have urges AND still choose not to act on them. The urge doesn't control me."

Resignation: "I'll always be anxious, so my life will always suck."

Acceptance: "I experience anxiety. Anxiety is uncomfortable. AND I can do meaningful things while feeling anxious."

EXERCISE 1: CLEAN PAIN VS. DIRTY PAIN IN MY LIFE

Identify a recent situation where you experienced clean pain that turned into dirty pain.

The situation:

_____

_____

The clean pain (the unavoidable discomfort):

_____

_____

How I struggled against it (what I told myself, what I tried to do):

_____

_____

_____

The dirty pain that resulted:

_____

_____

_____

What would acceptance have looked like instead?

_____

_____

_____

_____

Mindfulness: Being Present

Mindfulness is the practice of being fully present in this moment, without judgment.

You're NOT being mindful when:

- Ruminating about the past
- Worrying about the future
- Judging your experience as "good" or "bad"
- Trying to change what you're feeling
- Checked out or on autopilot

You ARE being mindful when:

- Noticing what's happening right now
- Observing without trying to change it
- Accepting your experience as it is
- Being curious about sensations, thoughts, feelings
- Fully engaged in the present moment

SKILL: BODY SCAN MEDITATION

The body scan is a mindfulness practice that helps you notice physical sensations without judgment. It's especially useful for learning to be with discomfort.

HOW TO PRACTICE (15 minutes):

1. Get comfortable

- Lie down or sit in a comfortable position
- Close your eyes or soften your gaze

2. Start with your breath

- Notice your breathing without changing it
- Feel the air moving in and out
- Take a few deep breaths

3. Scan your body from head to toe

- Start at the top of your head
- Slowly move your attention down through your body
- Notice any sensations: tension, warmth, tingling, pressure, pain, or nothing at all
- Don't try to change anything—just notice

4. When you notice tension or discomfort

- Breathe into that area
- Allow the sensation to be there
- Notice if it changes on its own
- Practice making room for it

5. Continue through your whole body

- Head, face, neck, shoulders
- Arms, hands, fingers
- Chest, back, stomach
- Hips, legs, feet, toes

6. End by noticing your whole body

- Feel yourself as a complete being
- Notice your breath again
- Slowly open your eyes

The goal: Not relaxation (though that may happen). The goal is awareness and acceptance of your body as it is.

BODY SCAN PRACTICE LOG

Practice the body scan at least 3 times this week. Track what you notice.

Day	Practiced (Y/N)	Duration	What I Noticed	What Was Difficult?
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				

At the end of the week:

What did I learn about my body?

Where do I typically hold tension?

Did I notice any connection between physical sensations and emotional states?

SKILL: URGE MINDFULNESS

This is a variation of urge surfing, but with deeper mindfulness practice.

HOW TO PRACTICE:

1. When an urge appears, don't fight it

- Notice: "An urge is present"
- Don't judge it or yourself

2. Get curious about the urge

- Where do I feel this in my body?
- What does it feel like exactly? (describe it)
- Is it moving or still?
- Does it have a temperature?
- Does it have a color or shape?

3. Notice your thoughts

- What thoughts accompany this urge?
- "I need this"
- "I can't handle this"
- "This will never go away"
- Just notice them, don't engage

4. Notice the action urge

- What does my body want to do?
- Notice the impulse without acting on it
- Feel the tension between urge and restraint

5. Breathe with it

- Take slow, deep breaths
- Imagine breathing into the sensation
- Make room for it
- Don't try to make it go away

6. Practice the "expansion" technique

- Instead of contracting around the discomfort, expand
- Create space around it
- Imagine your body as a vast container that can hold this discomfort
- The urge is present, AND there's room for it

7. Wait

- Commit to 15 minutes of being with the urge
- Notice how it changes
- Notice when it peaks
- Notice when it begins to decrease

EXERCISE 2: URGE MINDFULNESS PRACTICE

Practice urge mindfulness at least once this week with a real urge.

When did the urge occur? (Date/Time): _____

Initial intensity (1-10): _____

Where did I feel it in my body?

_____

What did it feel like? (Be descriptive)

_____

_____

What thoughts accompanied it?

_____

_____

What was the action urge? (What did my body want to do?)

_____

How long did I practice urge mindfulness? _____

Peak intensity (1-10): _____

Intensity after practice (1-10): _____

Did I act out? Yes / No

What did I learn from being mindful of the urge?

_____

_____

_____

What was most difficult about this practice?

The Expansion Technique

When you experience uncomfortable emotions or sensations, your natural response is to contract—tighten up, resist, fight.

The expansion technique teaches you to do the opposite: make space, open up, allow.

HOW IT WORKS:

1. Notice the discomfort

- Identify where you feel it in your body
- Give it a number (1-10 intensity)

2. Breathe into it

- Take slow, deep breaths
- Imagine breathing into that area of your body

3. Make space around it

- Instead of tightening around the sensation, relax around it
- Imagine the discomfort is an object
- Now imagine creating space around that object
- Your body is a vast container—there's room for this

4. Allow it to be there

- Don't try to push it away
- Don't try to make it smaller
- Just let it exist
- It can be there, and you can be okay

5. Notice what happens

- Often, the sensation changes when you stop fighting it
- It might get bigger at first, then smaller

- It might move
- It might stay the same—and that's okay too

EXERCISE 3: EXPANSION PRACTICE

Practice the expansion technique with an uncomfortable emotion or sensation.

What discomfort am I working with?

_____

Where do I feel it in my body?

_____

Initial intensity (1-10): _____

What happens when I breathe into it?

_____

_____

What happens when I make space around it instead of contracting?

_____

_____

Intensity after expansion (1-10): _____

What did I notice?

_____

_____

_____

_____

Willingness vs. Willfulness

WILLFULNESS is trying to control what you can't control.

- Fighting against urges
- Demanding that feelings go away
- Insisting reality be different than it is
- White-knuckling through discomfort

WILLINGNESS is accepting what is while choosing your actions.

- "I'm having an urge, AND I choose not to act"
- "I feel anxious, AND I can do what matters anyway"
- "This is uncomfortable, AND I'm willing to feel it"
- Opening to experience while directing behavior

The shift: From "I must eliminate this feeling" to "I can have this feeling and still move forward."

EXERCISE 4: WILLFULNESS VS. WILLINGNESS

Identify an area where you've been willful (trying to control what you can't):

_____

_____

What has this willfulness cost you?

_____

_____

What would willingness look like instead?

I can have/feel _____

AND I can still _____

_____

_____

Daily Acceptance Practice

This week, practice acceptance daily. Use this simple prompt:

"What am I unwilling to feel right now?"

Once you identify it, practice making room for it instead of fighting it.

DAILY ACCEPTANCE PRACTICE LOG

Day	What I Was Unwilling to Feel	Did I Practice Acceptance?	What Happened?
1			
2			

Day	What I Was Unwilling to Feel	Did I Practice Acceptance?	What Happened?
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

At the end of the week:

What did I notice about my relationship with discomfort?

Which practice was most helpful? (Body scan, urge mindfulness, expansion)

What was most challenging about acceptance this week?

How did acceptance affect my urges or behaviors?

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 12

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add focus on acceptance and mindfulness.

Additional tracking:

- When did I practice acceptance this week?
- What uncomfortable feelings did I allow instead of avoiding?
- Which mindfulness practices did I use?

[7 daily logs with same format as previous weeks—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 12 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 13, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 12 material
- [ ] Complete "Clean Pain vs. Dirty Pain" exercise
- [ ] Practice body scan at least 3 times this week
- [ ] Complete body scan practice log
- [ ] Practice urge mindfulness with at least one real urge
- [ ] Practice expansion technique
- [ ] Complete willfulness vs. willingness exercise
- [ ] Use daily acceptance practice prompt all 7 days
- [ ] Complete daily acceptance practice log
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days

Notes for Week 12:

END OF WEEK 12